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South Nyanza District, Southwestern Kenya, East Africa

Section Title(S)

CHANGING PATTERNS OF PREMARITAL SEXUAL BEHAVIOR

Each marketplace has its day of the week when activity is greatest and trading goes on; this is when girls dress up and go in groups to sell some family produce and be seen by boys. The boys and young men also attend, singly and in groups, looking for attractive girls. In the 1930's the young people used to perform traditional dances in the marketplace on market days but this was banned after the 1937 outbreak of mass rape and has never been resumed. Youths approach strange girls, often through girls they already know or through male friends who know them. There is an initial period of small talk in which the girl may immediately reject the boy by claiming that she is married or by assuming a cold and aloof attitude. If she is friendly and laughs, however, the boy is encouraged and may begin some sexual joking. If the girl is favorably inclined to him she will respond in kind, usually using terms of obscene abuse. The boy may grab her arm and attempt to pull her away from the group but she will refuse, at least until he buys her a present in one of the market shops or treats her to some food. Even then he may not succeed in detaching her from the other girls, and he will let her go after arranging a rendezvous and possibly promising a phonograph party. She may agree to the assignation but not show up, in which case the youth will try to woo her later with more gifts and provocative exhortations. Eventually she meets him at a small party in his house or in a secluded part of the bush or forest. The following is a story completion by a Gusii schoolboy writing in English; it is a typical account of a Gusii seduction.

Before they go into the forest Moraa [the girl] will be pretending not to be pleased with this boy for he is talking to her matters concerning sex. But as Gesimba is very serious about it, he will force her and even try to pull her into the forest. When Moraa is being pulled she will fall down, just pretending, and Gesimba having high sex now will lie with her. She will pretend to cry and Gesimba will be trying hard to get the one thing he only wants. He will just catch one of her thighs and lift it, and as a result he will get between the two thighs and push his male organ into the vagina. At this time she will be quiet and all the work will be going on smoothly. After he has spermed several times he will now be satisfied

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and leave her to dress properly, also himself dress, and thank her many thanks.

In this as in other accounts, it is assumed that the girl will resist and have to be forced even if she desires intercourse. The Gusii girl avoids looking into the eyes of her seducer during coitus, and some go so far as to cover their faces with their dresses. Some Gusii girls cry out of shame and revulsion after intercourse and, unlike Moraa of the fantasy, may refuse to repeat the act on the same occasion. They often become panicky about discovery of the illicit act and the possibility of a premarital pregnancy.

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With respect to premarital sexual activity, three types of Gusii girls may be distinguished. The first type is stigmatized as a "slut" (*omokayayu*) because she has achieved a reputation for promiscuity. This type of girl engages in 979 intercourse with men and boys she knows very slightly, and after relatively little persuasion. With her, resistance in coitus is probably conscious role-playing designed to please her lover. Some girls of this type occasionally take on a number of young men in succession. Although she is in demand as a sexual partner, a girl with this sort of reputation is considered highly undesirable as a wife and is ordinarily not married with bridewealth unless her marriage takes place at an early age before her reputation has spread. She is likely to elope from the home of her father or legitimate husband and live as the concubine of one man after another.

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